

“PROBUS WAS ALMOST A SECOND HANNIBAL BECAUSE OF HIS KNOWLEDGE OF WARFARE...”

Aurelius Victor, Roman historian and official, in *De Caesaribus*, c. 360

IN CHINA, THE FIRST EMPEROR OF THE WESTERN JIN DYNASTY, Wudi (r. 265–89), was a strong ruler who secured trade routes to the West and built a bridge over the Yellow River to improve communications. However, the **wars of the Three Kingdoms period** (see 231–244) had impoverished the state and as the tax burden rose, many peasants fled to landowners for protection, resulting in the **rise of private armies**.

In the Roman Empire, Emperor Aurelian—who was murdered in 275—was followed by two

short-lived emperors—Tacitus and Florianus—before Probus took power in 276. Within two years, Probus had **defeated the Goths** on the Danube and **pushed back the Franks** from the Rhine. A planned campaign against Persia was frustrated in 281 by the revolt of two usurpers in the West: Bonosus and Proculus. Despite his military successes, in 282 **Probus was murdered by his own troops**, who were resentful at being forced to work on civil engineering projects near Sirmium (in modern Serbia).

Jin sitting bear sculpture

The first half of the Jin dynasty under Wudi gave China a period of comparative peace and stability, which allowed the arts to flourish.



The Pyramid of the Moon at Teotihuacán (near modern Mexico City) was built some time after 200 at one end of the city's Avenue of the Dead; the Pyramid of the Sun sits at the other end.

IN 284, THE ROMAN ARMY IN ASIA MINOR PROCLAIMED **DIOCLES**, the former commander of the imperial bodyguard, **Emperor Diocletian** (r. 284–305). In 285, he defeated **Carinus** (the then emperor of the Western Empire) and started a **radical reorganization of the empire**, reforming the army, and subdividing provinces. The challenges on the frontier were too great to be faced alone; in 285, he appointed **Maximian** (250–310) **to rule alongside him**, first as Caesar (junior emperor) then as Augustus (senior emperor). Other problems with Britain's break from the empire under **Carausius** in 286 convinced Diocletian that more changes were necessary. In 293, he and Maximian appointed two Caesars: **Constantius Chlorus** (r. 293–306) to assist Diocletian in the Western Empire and **Galerius** (r. 293–311) to be Maximian's junior in the East. This **tetrarchy** (four emperor system) enjoyed early successes in Britain (296) and in Egypt (298). In 294, Diocletian **reformed the coinage**, reissuing new bronze and silver coins, and in 301 he issued an **Edict on Maximum Prices** to try to curb rising inflation. Unlike his other measures, this one failed.



Persian frieze

The Paikuli frieze celebrates the victories of Narseh in Armenia and justifies his deposition of predecessor Vahram III.

After the death of Shapur I in 272 Persia faced a **period of political instability**. In 293, **Narseh** (r. 293–302) ascended to the Persian throne. He resolved to recover land in Armenia and Mesopotamia that had been lost

to the Romans. He launched a major invasion in 296, **defeating** the Caesar **Galerius** in 297. The next year, however, Galerius smashed Narseh's army in Armenia and captured the Persian ruler's family. Galerius marched as far as Ctesiphon, which he captured in 298. Narseh was forced to make peace (**Treaty of Nisibis**). Persia remained at peace with the Romans for 40 years.

In the Valley of Mexico, the city of **Teotihuacán** **reached the peak of its power** around 300. Its main street—the Avenue of the Dead—ran between the Pyramid of the Moon and the Ciudadela (which may have been the palace of the ruler) and was lined with the residences of the lords of the city.

12 SQUARE MILES THE AREA OF TEOTIHUACAN CITY AT ITS PEAK

277 Mani (founder of Manichaeism) is crucified by the Persians

279 Jewish scholars in Tiberias publish a collection of Jewish laws and doctrines, the Talmud

276 Probus becomes Roman emperor after brief six-month reign of Tacitus

277–79 Probus expels the Franks from Gaul, and puts down unrest in Egypt and Illyria

280 Western Jin conquer the south of China and unite the country under their leader, Sima Yao

282 Probus killed at Sirmium in Illyria after a mutiny

283 Emperor Carus invades Persia and takes Seleucia and Ctesiphon; he dies mysteriously near Ctesiphon

284 Diocletian declared emperor after the murder of Carus's son of Numerianus

285 Diocletian reorganizes the empire, dividing power between two emperors; he rules the East and appoints Maximian to rule the West

288 Diocletian makes peace with Persia

291 Western Jin allow steppe peoples from north of the Great Wall to settle inside China

293 Diocletian establishes tetrarchy

297 Persians invade Armenia and defeat Roman emperor Galerius

c. 300 First minting of coins in Aksum (in ancient Ethiopia)

c. 300 Bantu peoples in Africa begin to herd cattle

287 Carausius seizes control of Britain and part of northern Gaul

c. 290 Elite Moche burials at Sipán, Peru

293 Stela 29 at Tikal is the first monument with the Maya calendar inscription of the "Long Date"

296 Narseh becomes ruler of Persia

c. 300 Armenia becomes first country to accept Christianity as a state religion

c. 300 Growth of Yamato state in Japan

c. 300 Settlement of Rapa Nui (Easter Island)